



Beyond Execution:

An Analytical Approach to LLB

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Finally, thank you to the Lethal League Community as a whole. You have transformed a mere game into a passion.

Preface

This guide is the spiritual successor to my previous one: The 5 Interactions Chart. It can (and should) be seen as an upgrade, since my goal in writing this was both to expand and correct the previous one.

The original contained ideas that were too abstract to be of any actual use, but it took me quite a long time to understand that it wasn't disregarded due to the stubbornness of the player base, but due to my own.

Hopefully I won't commit the same mistake twice in a row. 😊

To those unfamiliar with the game Lethal League Blaze, it is generally described as a projectile-based fighting game, similar to the real-world sport of dodgeball (though, as we will see further, it may be wiser to compare it to some other sports). This guide aims at providing a framework for understanding the game from an analytical point of view. In other words, and as suggested by the title, the focus will not be on execution, but on the theoretical and analytical aspects of the game. In simplified terms, it concerns itself with what you choose to do and the components behind strong choices, rather than a compendium of options and the way to execute them.

As with the previous iteration of this work, I believe that much of what you will read should already be a part of any experienced player's knowledge, even if only intuitively. Nonetheless, I truly believe taking the time to question and clarify these ideas is a boon to those looking to master the game, hopefully shedding light on some key abstract concepts.

Additionally, I hope to create a solid foundation for teaching newer players, rather than the usual approach of continually punishing them until they're able to slowly piece things together by themselves. It's hard enough to understand the game when it contains so many unique, but unorthodox, mechanics.

Finally, I'd like to stress that, though useful, this guide is no substitute for experience, nor is it fit for every type of player. In fact, I'd argue that it takes a very specific type of player to resonate with this method. However, I still believe that it can be of service throughout the various stages of your journey towards improvement, and will truly shine when used as a tool for post-game analysis (though it can still be useful in a round-by-round basis), playstyle discovery, and weakness mitigation.

Thank you for taking the time to read this. – CT

Introduction

If you know me, then you also know I'm a fan of charts. They are appealing and help make sense of otherwise confusing concepts (plus, they look really cool). So, I'll start by presenting you with a chart and then proceed to break it down into sections.

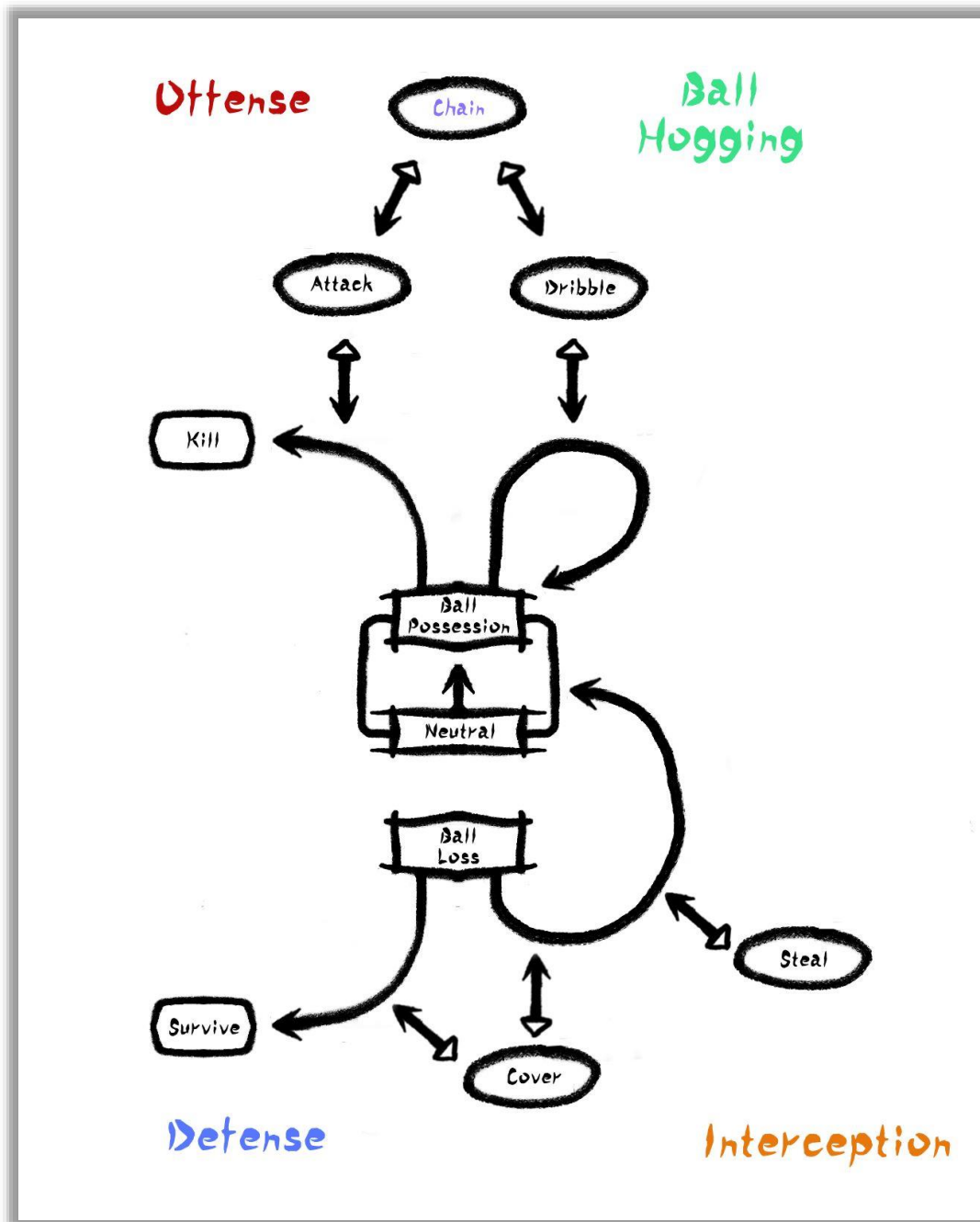


Figure 1. A representation of the 3 possible in-game states, as well as its objectives and mechanisms.

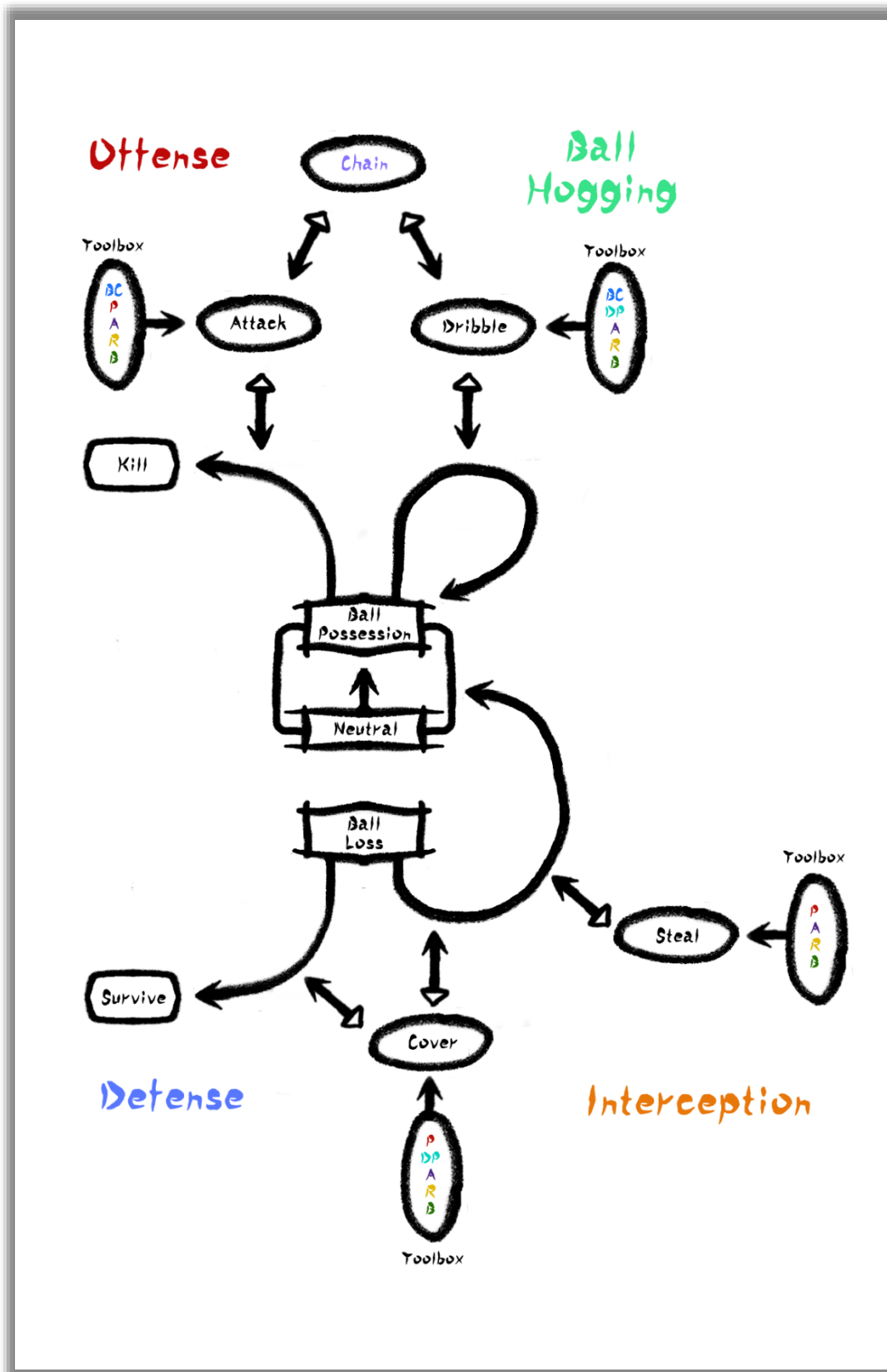


Figure 1.1. The full version of the states chart, complete with the tools available in each dimension.

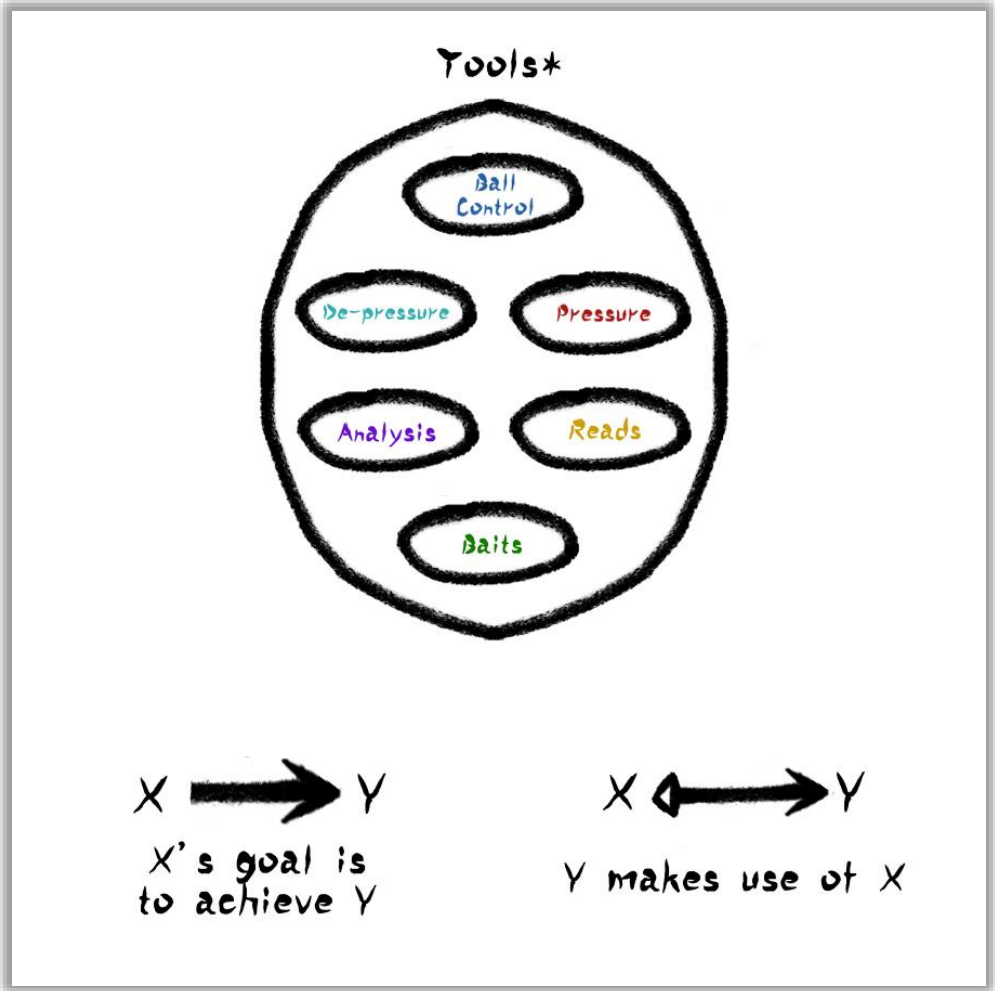


Figure 2. Explanation of the possible toolset tools and connectors.

Figure 1 is the general chart, while Figure 2 serves as a supplement to the chart itself (which we will explain later). With all the pieces laid down, let's get into the nitty gritty.

States

You can break your in-game state into 3 different variations:

Ball Possession (BP)

Ball Possession is a moment during which you have possession of the ball and are allowed to make use of it. More concretely, you can define it as having at least a set of 2 or more actions (swing, bunt, grab, special...) with which to interact with the ball, without the ball being intercepted. This set is called a *chain*.

As an example, imagine a situation in which you may bunt the ball twice uninterrupted, but where swinging would allow your opponent to intercept the ball. This is still ball possession, as choosing the correct option would have allowed you to keep the ball.

This is the state you always want to be in. Without ball possession, you won't be able to attack, thus preventing you from killing your opponent (with a few exceptions). This term also exists in sports such as Basketball and Soccer, and it is a well known fact that teams with a higher amount of ball possession are more likely to win the game.

As such, you have 2 objectives / dimensions when you are in the BP state.

1. *Hit / Kill your opponent. (Offense)*
2. *Maintain Ball Possession. (Ball Hogging)*

Neither of these should come as a surprise. You want to perform successful attacks against your opponent, but you also want to maintain BP in order to perform more and stronger attacks, while preventing your opponent from turning the tables.

The process of trying to hit your opponent is called **Offense** / Attacking, and the process of trying to maintain BP is called **Ball Hogging** / Dribbling. The underlying mechanism for achieving either objective is called a *chain*, and can be categorized into an *attack* or *dribble*, if the chain pertains to Offense or Ball Hogging, respectively. We will go more in-depth on these concepts later.

Ball Loss (BL)

Ball Loss is a moment during which your opponent has possession of the ball, preventing you from interacting with it. More concretely, you can define it as the opponent having at least a set of 2 or more actions with which to interact with the ball, which prevent you from intercepting the ball without getting hit.

As an example, imagine a situation in which the opponent may back bunt the ball twice, down bunt and swing or down bunt and throw. You may be able to intercept two of these, but if there is still a chain which prevents you from intercepting the ball without being forced to make a read, you are still in ball loss. Furthermore, you can consider a situation in which you will be able to cover the ball and be guaranteed BP. However, for the sake of simplicity, we'll still consider this BL until you actually interact with the ball (since you may fail at covering the angle and end up with the opponent's ball flying around the screen).

You want to avoid this state, independently of how good you are at playing in it. Being in BL prevents you from attacking your opponent and leaves you vulnerable to your opponent's offensive options.

As such, you have 2 objectives / dimensions when you are in the BL state.

1. *Survive / Defend your opponent's attacks. (**Defense**)*
2. *Either regain Ball Possession or, at the very least, Neutral State. (**Intercepting**)*

Usually, you'll want to prioritize surviving over regaining BP / N, but you can play around with your priorities and **Risk / Reward** assessment and go for a more defensive or active type of BL. Is offense the best defense? That's up for you to decide.

The process of trying to survive your opponent's offense is called **Defense / Covering**, and the process of trying to regain BP / N is called **Intercepting**. The underlying mechanism for achieving the 1st objective (Defense) is called a **cover**. When it comes to the 2nd objective (Intercepting), either **covers** or **steals** can be used. However, it's important to note that a cover can be either defensive or defensive and interceptive, but not just interceptive (that would be a steal). Essentially, a cover is a **reaction** to a threat your opponent has sent at you, where as a steal is a **proactive** measure, where you take the ball before your opponent can execute his threat. We will go more in-depth on these concepts later.

Neutral (N)

Neutral is a moment during which neither you nor your opponent have possession of the ball yet are both able to interact with it. More concretely, you can define it as neither player having at least a set of 2 or more actions with which to interact with the ball, preventing the other from intercepting the ball.

Neutral states can be hard to pinpoint, as it may often appear as though a player has BP, yet you are able to theoretically intercept every one of his chains, just can't find the correct way in time. Furthermore, situations in which your opponent can cover every single one of your options but doing so will allow you to then do the same, may also be considered Neutral. If you are able to recatch his option and gain BP, we will still consider this Neutral state up until you interact with the ball, for simplicity's sake.

Despite the hardship in pinpointing these situations, others are still obvious. The ball spawn at the beginning of the match or when a ball is downbunted and both players are facing the ball on opposite sides illustrate this quite well.

This state isn't inherently bad. When such situations occur, it usually turns into a reading contest, with each player trying to punish their opponent's option. Some common strategies are either trying to get the ball before the opponent or baiting the other player into taking it in a punishable way.

As such, you generally only have a single objective when you are in the N state.

1. Gain Ball Possession. (**Conversion**)

It is also technically possible to attack and hit your opponent when in pure N state (not to confuse this with going from N to BP), such as when you parry your opponent, grab a parry, downbunt and the opponent gets hit by it... This is quite viable, and you may even give up BP for a situation that might either hit the opponent or get into N state (often the case when you cover with downbunt instead of back bunt), but we'll cover this in the in-depth BP and BL section.

I probably won't be focusing on N state again since, despite being complex, it is usually either quite short or can be approximated in a fair way by think of the state as BP or BL. As an example, imagine a situation where you swing at the ball, and it goes flying around the screen. Theoretically, this could be N, or even turn to you being in BL, but it makes more sense to assume this as a continuation of your attack, and thus, of your BP (at least until the opponent either covers that angle or gets hit).

Thinking in States

If you've been playing for a while, chances are, you already think somewhat similarly (give or take). Thinking of the game in this way can be very advantageous, as it allows you to quickly separate your strengths, weaknesses, successes and mistakes into different categories, as well as quickly pinpoint your objectives, which can be particularly important in high-pressure situations.

In a sense, LLB and LL are special games, combining elements from both fighting and turn-based games. Solidifying your understanding of how these states work will almost always guarantee an increase in consistency by helping you create strategies and routines to fall back on.

Actions & Mechanisms

It might be relevant to denote what I have and will refer to in the future as actions and mechanisms. Let's start with actions.

Putting it simply, actions are the things you can execute, and are divided into 2 categories: Movement and Interactions.

Movement is the ability to move your character around and change its position.

Interactions are any actions you may do that can influence the state of the ball.

I think these concepts should be fairly intuitive, so I won't dwell on them for long. Essentially, actions like moving, jumping, crouching, wall mechanics... are categorized under movement, and actions like swinging, bunting, grabbing, certain specials... are categorized under interactions.

Actions, by themselves, are meaningless. They are atomic operations that you may perform, but, without intent, you are essentially just button mashing.

Mechanisms are what I referred to as Chains, Attacks, Dribbles, Covers and Steals. They are essentially what you'll be using to achieve a particular goal.

Chains are the underlying mechanisms to achieve the objectives of BP. They can be divided into **Attacks** for Offense or into **Dribbles** for Ball Hogging.

Covers are the underlying mechanisms of Defense.

Steals and **Covers** are the underlying mechanisms of Interception.

You may also think of Chains as a mechanism whose purpose is to create Attacks and Dribbles, the mechanisms underlying Offense and Ball Hogging, respectively.

Mechanisms are the execution of a combination of Actions, and you use tools to increase the number of options for a particular mechanism, as well as their potency.

Tools

Before we get into the details of BP and BL, I want to take a moment to explain how tools work (the secondary chart you saw at the beginning of the guide).

In essence tools are strategies you can utilize to increase the number or potency of a mechanic's options. They utilize Actions as a means to a goal.

Since many (but not all) tools are the same or similar across all mechanisms, I think giving a general idea of what they mean would be beneficial.

Ball Control (BC)

Ball Control is the ability to maneuver the ball in space in order to alter your options and / or arrive at more flexible positions. More concretely, it utilizes actions with the objective of increasing, substituting or increasing the potency of your current options for a given mechanism.

It might be simple to visualize it in this way: there is a clear difference between someone just mashing buttons and moving around randomly, compared to someone purposefully looking to change the ball's position. That is ball control.

Ball control is intimately tied to technical ability. The better you are at handling the ball (chaining interactions and movements), the faster and more precisely you can arrive at new positions. However, ball control doesn't require a high amount of technical skill. It helps to be able to do more things in a smaller amount of time, especially VS oppressive opponents or adept defenders, but in the end, the goal of controlling the ball's state is still there. Furthermore, it doesn't have to be flashy. Sometimes doing simpler chains is better than cramming in as many actions as you can, in the shortest amount of time possible (when dealing with very interceptive opponents, for example).

Thus, I like to differentiate 3 aspects of ball control: technical skill, steering and rhythm.

- Technical skill is how fast and precisely you are able to control the ball. In other words, someone very good at ball control should be able to execute any chain he desires, no matter how tight the timing may be.
- Steering is the ability to know what you can get away with, without the opponent intercepting the ball. A good example is knowing you can't do a

forward bunt next, or the opponent is able to reach the ball before you, and thus opting for an up bunt instead

- Rhythm is the tempo at which you chain ball interactions. Having a predictable rhythm (even if it's very fast) is bad, as it makes it easy for the opponent to guess your goal, and thus read what you'll do next. Try breaking up your tempo often when you have the ball! For example, doing a burst of quick bunts, followed by merely hovering around the ball for a few moments, can make your opponent wary to engage or allow you to parry them for mistakenly thinking they can go for a steal.

Ball control is perhaps the most important tool and is of high importance for any mechanism. If you're in BL, you must be aware of your opponent's ball control in order to understand their intent and successfully cover or steal, and if you're in BP, it's very important to creating new possible chains, or heightening existing ones.

BC has the advantage of not only allowing you to **increase the potency of your options**, but also to **increase or substitute the number of options you have**.

As a final note, I'll add that, although it might seem unintuitive, not doing anything or stalling when you have the ball may also be ball control. In the end, you're still controlling the state of the ball, while keeping BP.

Pressure (P)

Pressure is an attempt at exploiting the opponent's reactions and decision-making, and then punishing their chosen option. More concretely, it's the employment of mechanisms in such a way that the short window of time the opponent has to calculate the best countermeasure leads them to execute poor and punishable options.

Pressure is a very strong and intuitive tool. In essence, you are looking to exploit the short amount of time your opponent has to process your actions, preventing them from retaliating in a reasonable way. Because of this, pressure tends to be a close-range ordeal.

Correctly pressuring your opponent should lead them to either employing a sub-optimal (and thus punishable) response, or to fumbling and outright failing to deal with your option.

Pressure can also be very psychologically taxing, as the overwhelming fear of failing to respond correctly can snowball into further weak choices. In retrospect, dealing with a certain situation while under pressure may be relatively simple, but the doubt and fear, coupled with the inability to process things clearly, may result in defeat.

Even if you can successfully deal with an option when under pressure, you must be ready to retaliate, or the opponent may take advantage of your lack of attention to create another pressuring situation, resulting in an offensive barrage.

A warning though: pressure is a double-edged sword. If you go in expecting a certain response, you may be surprised when your opponent does something else, and thus become the victim of your own self-imposed pressure.

De-pressure (DP)

De-pressure is the utilization of actions in order to facilitate the process of **protecting** your character or your ball possession (defense and ball hogging). More concretely, it's the utilization of actions in such a way that you increase your **protective** options and their potency, decrease the opponent's **offensive / interceptive** options and their potency, or increase the amount of time you have to decide which protective option to choose.

Essentially, De-pressure is the Defense and ball Hogging equivalent of pressure, or in other words, it's the opposite of pressure.

An intuitive example of De-pressure is the defensive approach of **shadowing**. Shadowing occurs during BL and is essentially following your opponent both vertically and horizontally when they have BP, as it creates both Interceptive pressure and Defensive de-pressure. In this scenario, you are de-pressuring yourself by ensuring you can find relatively easy covers for the opponent's angles, without letting the ball bounce too much, or by allowing for simple safe zones to occur.

De-pressuring will make your life much, much easier, and might even make the Ball Hogging and Defending aspects of the game more enjoyable for you.

I won't dwell on this too much right now, as this tool has a lot of intricacies depending on the objective you apply it towards.

Analysis (A)

Analysis is the ability to observe your opponent's habits & strategy, and consequently applying mechanism options that exploit those patterns. More concretely, it's the careful analysis of your opponent's decisions and habits, then storing your conclusions and using them as criteria for your own decision-making.

Analysis is one of the higher-level tools to get a hold of, as it requires both experience and comfort in the other areas of the game to be applied successfully. It is also a tool that is intimately tied to this guide as a whole, since it can and should be used to analyze your opponent's playstyle within the guide's framework.

It is important to note that Analysis does not equal knowledge of a certain player's playstyle. For example, you may know some of the attacks I tend to go for, since we have played in the past. Applying this knowledge to better prepare against those options is not analysis (however, it is still very important to consider). That is merely the baseline for your playstyle in that match. Analysis pertains to observing the deviations and quirks in my playstyle, but within the scope of a burst, match or set of matches.

A player's decision-making is altered on a burst/match/daily basis due to a number of factors, both physiological and psychological, as well as a consequence of adapting to your own (their opponent's) playstyle, since they will counter-adapt to your adaptations. It is up to you to pick up on these habits and exploit them.

A player who is able to properly analyze both the opponent's execution habits and their strategy, will find themselves becoming a much more diverse player, one who is able to adapt to every situation they encounter. Having a solid and consistent playstyle is good, but you should always have some wiggle room for adaptation, or you'll find yourself being countered eventually.

Reads (R)

Reads are the pursuit of a potentially unsafe, but also potentially rewarding, option. More concretely, it is choosing mechanism options through prediction of your opponent's behavior, working under the assumption that your punishable option will go unpunished.

Reads are a controversial topic in LLB. Some hate them, most use them, a few swear

by them. Nonetheless, they exist, and you should learn how to use them and how to counter them.

Let's start by making a distinction. A guess is choosing a particular option, similarly at random or without much backing. A read is a substantiated guess, usually through analysis or situational awareness. So, to exemplify, imagine you find yourself immediately below Switch, he switch flips with an overhead smash, and you decide to bunt either left or right. You pick left. If you're doing this out of panic, and just hoping it's the right option, that would be a guess. However, if this has happened a few times throughout your sets with this opponent, and you notice he tends to flip opposite to where you're facing, this would be a read.

Now, read-heavy playstyles aren't very common in top play, and that is because they are not very consistent. Making correct reads consistently requires them to be substantiated. You can borrow from your experience, but once you make a certain read, a good player will pick up on it and change their approach (or not, to trip you up). Even if you are aware of this, this will force you to make another prediction – will they fall for it again, or not – and that is already much less substantiated than the assurance you would get after someone does something for the 3rd time in a row.

However, this does not mean you should avoid reads altogether. Some habits are hard to break, especially in high stress situations, so you should abuse that. If you see an opponent having a hard time NOT adapting or seeing that he breaks off from a given pattern, but falls back to it after some time, you should 100% punish them for it. Furthermore, some reads are often more rewarding than punishing (i.e., jumping to cover up and down angle, but forgetting about the straight).

Finally, I want to just make a “quick” reference to parry grabs. These are often seen as a 50/50. And in a way, they CAN be (if you're a CPU). However, if we exclude cases in which the ball you hit is inside your hitbox and the opponent has time to get next to you and thus, theoretically, react to a parry and either grab it or downbunt you, it is generally one of the weaker read options in the game. In this case, both parties require information (substantiation) in order to make the read and counter-read correctly. And the truth is, the one in hitlag (the one who may parry), has more of it than the opponent. All the one reading the parry knows is what option you threw out last time, as well as your current position and health. They, however, have freedom of movement and positioning, so you can better draw on your experience to make an informed decision on whether they will try to grab. On top of that, grab has a 4 frame delay, and does a maximum of 45% damage to the opponent's health, meaning you are likely to miss it, and even if you do hit it, at best you do 45% damage (at 100 health), whereas a miss will instantly kill you. On top of that, if you read that the opponent is not going to parry, and decide to bunt instead, unless the ball is close to the ground and inside their hitbox, a downbunt won't do much. This is

not me advocating for you NOT to use parry grabs, it's just an observation as to why you don't see top players going for dozens of parry grabs each round.

In conclusion, gather information, calculate the risk / reward metric for a given read, and make your decisions accordingly.

Baits (B)

Baits are an attempt to alter or complexify a straight-forward threat into a different one, catching your opponent off-guard. More concretely, it's the extension, interruption or modification of a given option, in order to punish your opponent's countermeasure to said option.

Baits are one of the more commonly used tools due to their sheer efficiency and intuitiveness. If you have an attack or defensive strategy that tends to be dealt with relatively easily, just mix it up.

An example of an offensive bait could be a parry bait, in which you send an angle that you expect your opponent to cover, yet reach the ball before they do, and parry them, punishing their original cover. Defensively speaking, you could start jumping in front of your opponent in hitlag, trying to bait them into sending a down-angle which you would be unable to cover, but fall at the last second in order to catch that angle instead.

The number of existing baits is not just extensive, but technically infinite. The only limiting factor is their credibility, your ability, and your creativity. Nonetheless, some of them are both easy and very effective. The previous two are examples of that, but you may also speak of swing baits, steal baits, wall baits (where you bait your opponent into hitting the ball at the wall, in order to downbunt them afterwards)...

We will get into how baits can affect each dimension of the chart later, but the general idea should be simple for even the newest player to adopt.

Dimensions

Let's delve deeper into how each dimension / objective (Defense, Interception, Offense and Ball Hogging) works, how you can get better at them, and the toolboxes for each one.

Defense

For as long as I can remember, defense has been the most underdeveloped dimension of all. Especially in BL, people tend to learn the basics of defense, and then eventually gravitate towards interception as their dimension of choice.

In part, it's probably cultural. There is no greater feeling than watching someone whip out an insane combo, ingenious attack, or apply overwhelming pressure in interception. In contrast, defense is generally understated, gradual, and not straightforward to learn.

However, there are those who find pleasure in shutting down absolutely everything their opponent can do, and some of the best players in LL history have been considered defensive geniuses. Should you aspire to be one such player, I recommend you spend some time developing your defensive ability.

From my experience, there are a few ways to make the learning of defense less grueling:

1. Learn defensive mechanisms. Learning which tools you may use in order to defend a particular situation is a must. Be it tap charging, backbunts, saf zoning, downbunts, falling bunts, rising bunts, wiggle taps, slide covers, spike covers, charge covers... all of them have their upsides, downsides, and usages. Learn your options, and how to execute them.
2. Take note of situations you are not comfortable in. Whenever you find yourself in a spot which you are unsure on how to cover, or end up relying on a read to survive, I recommend spending some time researching how to deal with it. This may be tedious, and may require you to look at frame data, ask for advice or simulate the situation with an angle tool. However, once you learn it, it will become second nature.
3. Record your matches. Paying attention to everything that is going on in a match is an excruciating endeavor. Even if you are fully focused, you may

rewatch a match and suddenly find a different solution that you hadn't thought of before, or a situation that you struggle with consistently. I always tell my students: record all your matches. Worst case scenario, you won't review them. Best case scenario, you'll find a defensive gem.

4. Watch top players. The best way to learn is watching someone more experienced do it. This applies to all areas in our lives, but in a competitive game like LLB, this is both particularly useful and extremely accessible. Learn from your elders! (But take everything with a grain of salt)
5. Do defensive drills. If you've ever gone through the process of learning how to tap charge, you'll know it takes time to get it down consistently. I didn't even know how to do it until a top player spent some time teaching me, around 700hrs in. Do you have something you aren't very good at dealing with? Grab a friend and practice together.

Now, when I speak of defense I don't just mean sticking to the floor and trying to deal with everything your opponent throws at you. That would be bouldering, which is just a fancy word for sandbagging. Be active in your defense - good defense isn't just about surviving. As we talked about before, a cover can be both defensive and interceptive at the same time. You should try and find ways to cover things in such a way that you regain BP afterwards. If you can't find one, chances are you either put yourself in a bad spot or just don't know how to do it yet.

Pure defense will keep you alive, but it won't get you the ball. Thus, it's important to balance your passiveness. If you're having a hard time surviving your opponent's attacks, it might be wise to take on a more defensive stance. However, if your problem is being unable to get to Ball Possession, you might want to gravitate to a more interceptive stance.

Oh, and one final note: just because something worked, it doesn't mean it's a good way to cover something. Don't become complacent. Charge covers are cute, but you'll be crying if someone decides to swing bait you.

Now, let's talk about the tools available for **all** covers, both defensive and interceptive. This is only because a cover can be defensive, defensive and interceptive, but not just interceptive (that would be a steal). I could have added a section on interceptive covers in the following chapter, but I believe this division is a little more intuitive.

De-pressure (covers)

If you've ever watched the original **The Fast and The Furious** you might remember one of the first scenes where Brian races Dominic and almost beats him. Afterwards, he claims he "almost had" Dominic. To this, Dominic goes on an iconic speech where he points out how, despite how close the race was, Brian basically destroyed his car in an attempt to win the race, where as Dominic always had it under control.

De-pressure is somewhat like that. Yes, you might have been able to survive a complex attack from your opponent, but a truly experienced defensive player wouldn't have had to deal with the complexity of that attack in the first place.

When you de-pressure yourself, you're trying to either reduce your opponent's options, or minimize the difficulty of defending them. This means you need to move around and whittle away at what your opponent can do. If your opponent jumps with the ball, rather than just standing around, following him into the air is often a much better option, as you can find a sweet spot to cover all possible angles. Safezoning, crouching, jumping and corner camping (goblin tech) are all great de-pressuring tools. Some specials, like tauntflip, or grid's alt special are also great ways to de-pressure yourself, as are characters with instant specials (such as latch, raptor and grid), since you can safely smash without the downside of giving the ball back to your opponent.

Remember, a good defender finds the easiest ways to cover, not the flashiest.

Pressure (covers)

Pressure when covering is somewhat misleading because you aren't just making use of covers themselves. You're making use of the possibility of a steal in order to force your opponent to do certain things.

Think about it: how many times have you sent the ball away just from seeing your opponent come closer? BL is generally seen as a moment of desperation, but the ability to steal the ball from your opponent, possibly parrying them in the process, might make you think otherwise.

Pressure while covering is all about taking territory away from your opponent. You want to push them back until they are **forced** to hit the ball, otherwise you might steal it from them, which prevents them from actually sending out a threatening option.

Now, be careful. Push your luck too much, and you might get burned. Approaching your opponent isn't as easy as it sounds, and if you focus too hard on pressuring them, you might not be able to react in a timely manner. I have noticed that players are most susceptible to reaction checks when they are moving towards you, likely because their mind is too focused on gauging the distances and your potential options.

Pressure is not a must, but it prevents you from being at the mercy of your opponent, giving you a chance to have a say in what's going on.

Analysis (covers)

This one is pretty straightforward. Pay attention to your opponent and you'll have an easier time defending!

But in all seriousness, don't just let yourself react to what is coming towards you. You should keep track of everything your opponent can do, so you can be better prepared to deal with it.

Much more than that though, you should take a mental note of your opponent's patterns. Something they do might seem very alien or difficult to cover, but after they do it for the 11th time that game, you will have an easier time dealing with it.

All too often I see players who have clearly spent a lot of time mastering a particular setup in training mode, or mastering wall tech. However, once we move past that, they fall short in their ability to create threats, so my score tends to go up the longer we play. This is a great party trick if you want to cosplay as a hero in tournament and do comeback after comeback.

Furthermore, if you notice that your opponent has a bad habit when it comes to offense, you should exploit it. For example, if you notice they always rush you right after they send the ball at you, in hopes of stealing your bunt, you should try to parry or downbunt them instead.

Reads (covers)

Everyone makes reads when it comes to covering the ball. LLB is a complex and very fast paced game, where you seldom have time to think about the optimal way to cover something. On top of that, making a read can lead to an interceptive cover, rather than a safer defensive cover, which will prevent you from transitioning to BP.

Minor reads when covering can be very rewarding without too much risk. Jump bunting is one such example: you cover the most threatening angles, up and down, and safezone the straight, which you can later catch with a spike or some other option (provided your opponent doesn't mix you up).

Another common tactic is pre-emptively bunting or swinging, before your opponent actually hits the ball. Once you've played the game for a long time, you start to gain some awareness of when an opponent is going to do something, so you don't have to waste any time thinking about it. However, be careful. If someone picks up that habit of yours, you can be in a heap of trouble.

In general, you should sneak in some minor reads when it's rewarding and save your riskier reads for when you are very confident or completely lost on what to do.

Baits (covers)

Baiting is a relatively minor aspect of coverage. There is only so much you can do to trick your opponent regarding how you're going to cover.

Nonetheless, if you are aware of your common cover patterns, you can try and condition them into believing you're going to cover a certain way, and then cover in a more rewarding fashion.

You may also try and pretend you're going for a certain option, such as jumping or bunt spamming to trick them into thinking you're going to do cover in some way, and then change it up at the last minute.

Finally, a very common strategy is to try and bait out a parry, so you can bunt steal the ball away from them immediately, or downbunt them after the fact.

Interception

O, wonderful interception! Everyone loves you; everyone hates you. It's great when you're the one dishing it out, but if you ever find yourself dealing with someone who will just relentlessly nag you, trying to take the ball away from your hands, you might end up wanting to uninstall the game immediately afterwards.

This is usually what players tend to gravitate towards, especially when they are starting out. When you have no idea of how to cover anything, your first instinct is usually either to back off or go and get the ball before them (usually the latter). As

such, interception can very easily become a crutch for those with a lack of defensive ability. And that is because steals are extremely powerful in LLB. Allow me to borrow the concept from basketball:

“In basketball, a steal occurs when a defensive player legally causes a turnover by their positive, aggressive action(s)”. [\[FIBA Statistics Manual 2005\]](#)

In LLB, steals work in very much the same way: you take the ball away from your opponent's hands before they even have a chance to do anything. Unlike steals, you aren't just reacting to what your opponent sends out; you are actively shutting them down.

Now, I'm not saying interception is the end all be all when it comes to BL. It has very clear downsides. Obviously, there is the risk of messing up and getting parried, but you are also reducing the amount of time you have to react to things, and by expending your mental capacity with trying to take the ball away from your opponent, you are effectively lowering your ability to deal with their threats.

Interception is its own game. I have heard many players talk about how they detest parries and steals and aggressive play, because it takes away from the complexity and fun of the game. I can understand their point, but I can't bring myself to agree.

Take away interception and you're basically playing glorified pong. If you find that all of your games are spent trying to not get stolen or parried, it's likely that you have to spend some time training how to properly ball hog. If, on the other hand, you find yourself constantly parrying your opponent's futile attempts at steals, then maybe you should find better opponents.

Before we move on, I'd like to point out that steals actually have 3 different phases.

1. The approach
2. The Steal
3. The Conversion

Approaching is generally the hardest part. You have to try and close the gap, while making sure you can cover anything they send at you.

Once you're in range, all you have to do is wait for the right time to strike. If you're lucky enough to either parry or hit your opponent, then you're set.

However, if that's not the case, or if you steal with a bunt instead, you'll need to be ready to convert that steal into BP. This usually means creating some distance with the ball, which is easier said than done. Players who have good ball control tend to have an easier time doing this.

You might be good at some of these, but not all of them, which can make you uncomfortable trying to steal the ball from your opponent. I recommend taking some

time into looking at what you are good at, and what you could improve on, especially if you find a buddy to help you out by trying to hog the ball.

Let's look at which tools you can apply to improve your steal potential.

Pressure (steals)

Bet you weren't expecting that one! Just kidding.

Pressure is the bread and butter of steals. The mere act of **attempting** a steal creates pressure. However, not all pressures are created equal.

There is a myriad of different ways to apply pressure. You can stand behind your opponent, constantly swinging, trying to get the ball before them; you can do guerilla tactics, where you swoop in and out, trying find an opening; you can menacingly stand behind them, waiting for them to mess up and punish them for it; you can slowly take territory away from them, pushing them toward the ceiling or wall until they are forced to either give the ball up or get parried. It's up to you to devise your own way to apply pressure.

The mental toll you put on your opponent is another big advantage of pressure. No one wants to die to a parry steal, so you might often end up making subpar decisions just for safety.

Experiment with different types of pressure and find one that suits your playstyle. Just remember, if you're not making your opponent sweat, you're probably not doing a good job.

I see people who are inexperienced in pressuring their opponent and I can't help but feel only a slight annoyance at the fact that I know I'm just going to shutdown their attempts at predictable steals. They might as well let me play in peace and play more defensively. When you pressure, you must create threats, not just mindlessly rush at the ball like a dog in the park.

Analysis (steals)

Analyzing is the most important step towards efficient and consistent steals. On a surface level, you'll need to pay attention to your opponent's movement and bunting pattern in order to find the right time to strike. However, it goes much deeper than that.

Have you ever had a feeling that you could just predict what your opponent is going to do with the ball after just a few matches? That's the feeling you should tap into when it comes to steals. You analyze their patterns and use that to either close the gap between you and your opponent or just outright snatch the ball from them.

However, analyzing isn't easy, especially against opponents who are proficient in ball hogging, as they will react to what you do and change their behavior.

Something I believe is extremely important when it comes to analyzing your opponent is probing. Essentially, it's trying a bunch of different approaches so you can understand how they react to different approaches; it's the equivalent of poking a patient in different places, trying to gauge out a reaction from them. Once you know which buttons to push, all you have to do is push them harder.

Reads (steals)

I'm not even sure if it's worth writing this section.

The whole concept of reads when it comes to steals is very simple. You basically gage your opponent's ball control patterns and predict their behavior, effectively reacting to their option before they have time to punish them.

The most common way of reading when it comes to steals is to just predict a bunt, jump in, and take it. However, you can also go one step further and try and read that they will parry the ball and then grab it.

As with all reads, don't get overzealous, and don't depend on them. They are a good tool, but they aren't a full workshop. It's better to wait and live rather than jump in and die.

Baits (steals)

This one can be a bit tricky. Baiting your opponent when attempting a steal can be immensely helpful, but the stress of being so close to your opponent can be daunting. If you mess up, you might end up not being able to react in time, get parried, or get hit in recovery.

There are many ways to go about it, but you are basically relying on pressure in order to bait your opponent into thinking you're going to attempt a steal, similarly to pressure when it comes to steals.

I know a few players who basically never actually attempt a steal. They just stand there and let their presence do all the work. Once your opponent sees you next to them, it's almost instinctive to either try and run a way or hit the ball. In both cases, you create a predictable situation which you can exploit (provided you don't mess up).

Something else you can do is quickly switching from passive play to very aggressive play. This is a phenomenal way to facilitate your approach, as you can focus on defense when playing more passively but swooping in when you see an opportunity.

If you find yourself unable to get to your opponent or finding a hole in their ball control, I recommend playing around with baits. Most people will play it safe and give the ball away, one way or another.

Offense

This is what everyone has been waiting for. Everyone (almost everyone) loves offense. If there's anything that will put a smile on a Lethal League player's face, it's executing a successful attack. This whole guide has been framed as a battle to get ball possession, and this is what you are trying to achieve.

Offense is also, by far, the most developed dimension out of all 4. The amount of options you have give you boundless freedom to execute attacks that can be as ingenious, complex, flashy, or efficient, as you'd like.

For a new player, the achievable complexity of attacks that you can create can seem incredibly daunting, but you can narrow it down to 4 essential types:

- Angle attacks
- Timing mixups / Frame traps
- Parry / RPS setups
- Special setups

This might seem like a simplification, but the number of ways you can create any of the following attacks is endless. Also, just note that some specials will only do the previous types of attacks, but when you factor in specials such as pushbox, spray, bubble... it seems better to just create their own category. If I'm missing any other base attack types, I apologize, but I believe this accurately narrows it down.

Understanding that, despite being able to create an endless number of mixes, there is a limited number of ways with which you can kill, should allow you to be more

successful with your offense, as well as increase your ability to defend against said attacks.

However, complexity comes at a price. We need to be able to keep the ball in order to complexify our attacks, and longer combos and strings aren't necessarily better.

Through my eyes, the way people approach offense has drastically changed throughout the years. Initially, you used to have those who had uncanny combos, those who had fundamental attacks, those who used smart setups to kill, and those who relied on a lot of guess work and adaptation.

Nowadays, this has become much more muddled (which is a good thing). Most top players don't have a single trademark of their gameplay, namely because people have learned how to deal with more things. If you're stuck with a single playstyle, you'll eventually be shut down by someone. It's also why many old players used to have **that one opponent** who they just had a hard time with.

As various strategies have been weeded out or normalized, the need for innovation is also a requirement for top play. Even characters with extremely strong specials and angles need something more to keep them going.

Offense is one of the biggest barriers between different groups of players. The ability to create threatening attacks is one of the things that differentiates a new player from an adept player, the amount of offensive options, as well as their consistency, will differentiate an adept player from a good player, and the ability to adapt and innovate is what sets top players apart.

Another important question is whether to utilize setups vs improvisation. In reality, improvisation is usually just chaining simple setups together, much like chains are the chaining of different actions together. Setups have the advantage of consistency, but may fall short when it comes to innovation and adaptability. In contrast, improvisation allows you to cater to the situation at hand, but is more inconsistent and volatile. Generally speaking, a good mix of both will allow you to explore and adapt, while maintaining a set of attacks that you can fall back on.

Though we can speak of players in term of their preferred dimensions for both BL and BP, we can also distinguish players by their preferred offensive patterns. Though most people have the ability to adapt and diversify their playstyle, we all tend to have an essential pattern of offense, much like the original top players. This isn't necessarily a bad thing, as it allows you to have a consistent offensive framework which you can develop. Just be careful not to become too dependent on it.

All right, unto the toolset.

Ball Control (attacks)

Ball control is not just important, but essential in offense. It doesn't have to be extremely complex, but if you have the offensive creativity of a top player, but are stuck with the ball control of a new player, you **will** become stuck. Gone are the times where bunt into smash was a viable offensive option. You must be able to handle the ball if you hope to become good at the game.

Again, by no means does this mean you have to be a ball control extraordinaire. As I pointed out earlier, ball control can be as simple as handling the ball for a few bunts, or chaining things together.

When we have the ball, we want to create an attack that will kill or hit the opponent. However, it can't be any attack. If your attacks are simple, they will usually be simple to defend. Thus, we combo for various reasons:

1. Change our position AND keep the ball. (Ball hogging)
2. Force the opponent to have to defend more and more complex options

Because of N°2, people will try to get close and steal the ball (try to limit your options), and so:

3. Bait people into trying to get the ball & then punish them.

Killing with a combo feels good because we are TRULY defeating the opponent. We are breaking their defense or punishing their aggressiveness. If the opponent doesn't move or react to anything, it doesn't feel as good to kill with a combo.

Ball Control is a multiplier to your offense. It's like $\text{Attack Skill} \times \text{Ball control Skill} = \text{Attack Power}$. So, you must try and do all those 3 things to be successful.

Imagine candy. A simple attack is a bunt and hit with special. That's 3 actions. But a strong combo can have like 20 actions. But if you always do 20 action attacks, or try to always do 20 action attacks, I never have to fear basic 2 action attacks.

A great, fun top-level game comes when you need to fear 2 action attacks, 5 actions, 20 and even 30 action attacks. But since simpler attacks are also simpler to defend or predict, eventually we start doing harder and harder attacks. But we still have to think: "Ok, he can do a simple attack or punish me from trying to steal". You earn space and respect from your opponent when they know you can do a simple attack or punish them at any moment.

Ball control is essential, as well as a balancing act. Execute according to your needs, abilities, and interests. No more, no less.

Finally, it's important to note that attacks are just chains, and chains can and should be a hybrid of both offense and ball hogging. My own BP playstyle is heavily focused on sending out a multitude of attacks, recovering them before my opponent, and continuing with my ball hogging. This makes it very hard for my opponents to predict what I'll do, as well as how to approach.

Pressure (attacks)

Pressure is another great way to make your opponent's life more difficult. Imagine trying to juggle 3 balls. For many, that's not too bad. Now, try doing it with a gun pointed to your head. Not so easy now, is it?

Pressure is essentially reducing your opponent's ability to make good decisions due to a perceived increase in complexity (which often isn't real), and it can come in many forms. You can just bunt up and down, and the sheer focus your opponent will have to muster in order to react to your attacks is likely to make him stutter. Sending out many attacks will also make it harder for your opponent to react correctly each time.

Distance or speed is also a big factor when it comes to pressure. The closer you are, the less time your opponent has to react to your attack, as well as cover safely without getting stolen immediately after, or getting parried due to your proximity. Conversely, the speed at which the ball travels also creates a high amount of pressure, and is one of the main reasons instant specials are so efficient.

Even the way you conduct your chains can be pressuring. Just bunting in order to keep ball control is not particularly efficient, that would be pure ball hogging. A better method would be to do a hybrid chain where you interleave bunts with hits. That way, your opponent can't just approach carelessly.

Analysis (attacks)

It's important to be able to dish out strong attacks, but analysis allows you to employ and devise attacks that are catered to whatever situation you are in.

In fact, I'd argue that offense is the best place to apply analysis. Everyone is susceptible to specific types of attacks and it's your job to find them. Furthermore, even if someone survives a given attack, it doesn't mean there is nothing to learn there. Take, for example, someone who always bunts up when covering a reaction check. You can use that to your advantage and go for a bunt steal next time. Or imagine a player who always jumps to cover in a given situation. You can take that into account a throw out a straight angle next time, creating a lawnmower.

However, it's important not to overuse your hand. If you see someone consistently die to something, don't do it over and over, as this will allow them to get acclimated to said option. A better response might be to interleave said attack with other ones.

Analyzing is a good way to understand how complex your attacks should be. If you see someone consistently surviving your attacks, it might be a good idea to complexify a bit. If, on the other hand, you find yourself losing the ball quite often, perhaps you should simplify your control and go for easier but controllable situations.

Finally, I'd like to point out that analysis is great, but you need to have an attack repertoire that is large enough for you to be able to pick, choose, dismantle and reassemble them into the perfect attack for the situation you are in. If you are an adept player, you might have a few tricks up your sleeve, but they might not be enough to offer you the adaptability you desire. A perfect player would have no attack pattern, but be able to create them on the fly to accommodate to his opponent's weaknesses.

Reads (attacks)

Utilizing reads when it comes to attacks is something we do constantly. Unless you're always going for frame traps in which you absolutely know it's going to kill, everything is theoretically read. Even so, it seems more sensible to categorize offensive reads as attacks that can backfire.

For example, reaction checks. These can either result in a quick kill or they can lead to you losing BP. Now, losing BP isn't the end of the world, but it's clearly not desirable, especially if your opponent is good in BP.

Another example are dives, in which you downbunt the ball from mid screen, into your opponent, and try to reach it and parry them before they can react. If all goes well, they'll die, but if they can react in time or counter-read you, they might parry or parry grab you instead.

Attack reads do have the added bonus of being harder to predict than other options, seeing as you aren't expecting the other person to do something that could potentially backfire. On top of that, a safe attack inherently limits your options to what is, well... safe. On the other hand, a read attack is just saying "I can go for any attack I want, but it might fail.". This freedom encompasses the ability to go for very strong attacks, albeit at a cost. Still, make sure your read is well substantiated and that you don't overdo read attacks, or your opponent may punish you for it.

This might sound repetitive by now, but reads are all about the risk / reward ratio. In this case, they are all extremely desirable because you will always be getting the ultimate reward: hitting your opponent. In contrast, you can have safer attacks that won't backfire as easily. For example, sending a straight mid screen. In this case, you aren't hitting your opponent, but he might jump into it and die, and jumping to catch the straight isn't a trivial thing to do. Another thing you may do is send an angle flying around the screen. If you see they're going to catch it, you can just get it before them, or try and mix them up, but the reality is that this situation has a lot less kill potential than some read attacks, which force your opponent to make a hard decision in a short amount of time. If you find yourself lacking in kill potential, going for riskier, yet more threatening, attacks, might be the way to go.

Baits (attacks)

Baits are the ultimate way to branch out your offensive options.

If you've used to playing good players, you learn never to take anything the throw at you at face value. That's because each attack they send is usually layered with different threats. Your instincts might compel you to cover that angle your opponent is sending at you, but if you understand that they can reach the ball before you, then you might decide to back up a bit before you do, or you might get parry baited or be hit by a grab mixup.

In fact, many baits are just different mixups of the same setup. Note that by setup I mean a pre-determined attack pattern, and mixup is simple the final step in said setup. For example, you might finish an attack with a hit, or with a throw. These will offer different timings which your opponent needs to be ready to deal with in order to survive.

Remember when I spoke about the essential types of attacks? Baits are basically trading a given attack type for another one, or a variation of the same one. In such a high-speed game, our brains tend to instantly deal with the threat in front of us, blinding us to other possibilities. Make use of that and throw your opponents a curve ball as often as possible.

This is also a smooth transition into our next segment, ball hogging. By pretending to go for an attack and then cancelling it into ball hogging, you allow yourself to gain some space and the ability to create new, potentially stronger, attacks.

Ball Hogging

Imagine you're playing volleyball with a bunch of friends, except you can do as many passes as you want, provided you don't mess up. However, imagine the other teams has a special player who can come into your side of the court and steal the ball from you, instantly winning the point if they can make it touch the floor afterwards. Ball hogging functions somewhat like that.

Your ultimate goal in BP is to kill, but hanging unto the ball allows you to set up stronger attacks. On top of that, while the other team's special player is dancing around trying to snatch the ball from you, you can exploit the fact that they currently have one less player on their side of the court and execute an attack.

This analogy is a bit convoluted, I know, but bear with me. When you have the ball, you give yourself the option to complexify your attacks and reach stronger offensive positions. As such, your opponent is unlikely to let you get away with it, so they'll follow you around trying to intercept it. This is in and of itself a good time to attack, as they might become vulnerable while intercepting.

You're dancing around (dribbling) with the ball, until you find a good time to strike by either confusing your opponent, exploiting a strong position you have found yourself in, or tripping an opponent who has gotten too close to you.

Now, dribbling is an extremely strong mechanism, but you need to know when to stop and convert it into an attack. That's where hybrid chains come in. If you dribble and create threats at the same time, you can just decide when one of the threats you have made is good enough to use, and attack your opponent. Furthermore, they will be wearier to engage due to the fear of being crossed up.

Ball hogging might be the hardest dimension to master, as it requires a solid knowledge of all other dimensions, as well as good ball control. You need to understand offense so you can gauge when you're in a prime position to attack; you need to understand defense so you can understand how and what your opponent is covering; you need to understand interception so the ball isn't immediately snatched from your hands while dribbling the ball.

The most common thing I tell players who have a hard time killing their opponent is "Well, don't send your attack then. Find a better one." That's easier said than done, but unless you find distinct pleasure in dancing around with the ball, we all have the urge to attack as soon as we see a glimmer of hope. Instead, train yourself to only stop dribbling if you must, or if an attack is stronger than your $\frac{\text{Attack potential}}{\text{Risk}}$, if you were to keep on dribbling the ball.

In essence, ball hogging is strong, but don't ball hog just because you want to. It provides very clear benefits, but also comes with risks that you want to avoid. There are many players who find no need to ball hog for very long, unless they just can't

find a way to kill, and instead rely of applying tools from the offensive toolset in order to elevate their options.

Finally, here are the tools you can use to make your dribbles more effective.

Ball Control (dribbles)

Dribbling doesn't exist without ball control. It's like trying to dribble a basketball with no arms, it just doesn't make sense. If you want to become a better dribbler you will have to either spend some time in training mode, or learn through repetition in game (hopefully both).

Now, dribbling isn't just about being fast and being able to bunt a lot. As I mentioned in the general description of ball control, you need to focus not just on your technical ability, but also your steering and rhythm. Playing around with different ways to move the ball to different positions is a must, and chaining bunts with hits is paramount.

And ball control isn't just about getting the ball where you want it to. You also want to be unpredictable. You might always be able to get the ball where you want it to, but if your opponent knows where you're going, it will be easier for them to cover your attack afterwards. Instead, having varied and polyvalent dribbles will give you more options, with the added bonus of unpredictability due to the higher difficulty in discerning your goal.

I won't dwell on this any further since the rest is all about experience and execution, but you should consider spending some time becoming comfortable with your character. Having better control is always a plus.

De-pressure (dribbles)

This is the only other time you're going to need to de-pressure yourself, and it's a lot harder than when you de-pressure yourself to cover the ball. This is because de-pressure when dribbling isn't straightforward and the risks of failing tend to be graver.

It's no use dribbling the ball if you're going to get stolen from it, and as soon as your opponent is on top of you, it's usually too late. As such, you should learn how to keep

your opponent at arm's length, as well as how not to be caught in bunt or hit recovery when dribbling.

At the same time, remember that interception is a risky ordeal. If your opponent over-extends their space, they are likely to be punished severely for it, usually in the form of a timing or parry mixup. When an interceptive and a ball hoggish player meet, most of the stocks will be determined by who can out-perform who in their area of expertise, so it's up to you to punish their pressure and come out on top.

We will talk a little bit on how to abuse your opponent's eagerness to get the ball when we talk about baits, but if you can avoid it all together by creating some space between the both of you, that's perfect.

Use verticality to your advantage, and make use of the wall in order to recover chains before your opponent has time to step in. Finally, be wary of parry spamming. A good player might take notice and grab you after a while. Using different rhythms in order to punish their steals is a great way to avoid this trap.

Analysis (dribbles)

Analysis when it comes to ball hogging is a bittersweet deal, since most of your analysis will come from when you mess up and they get a steal from you. Nonetheless, it's better to learn from your mistakes in order to prevent them from happening time and time again.

People tend to expect certain angles when you play. Dice up angle, switch up angle, candy down angle... these are all staples because of how strong or useful they are. Pay attention to your opponent's internal bias towards what you are going to do, and deviate from it in order to keep the ball.

Of course, it's also possible to analyze what your opponent does even without being stolen. This can help you construct different dribbles that, despite achieving the same goal of keeping BP, can be much more efficient at creating threats in the long run. If your opponent always expects a certain pattern of bunting to get to the ceiling, finding a different one might give you the small edge you need in order to get that attack in.

Analysis is also the perfect time to discern which steering and rhythms your opponent is most susceptible to when it comes to ball control. If you find that your opponent tends to expect a hit after 1 or 2 bunts, or if they assume you're going to the ceiling, try and bunt a few more times, or utilize your fast fall to cross them up.

Reads (dribbles)

I am usually against reads when it comes to dribbles, since they are at odds with the goal of being safe and keeping the ball for as long as possible. You usually do not need to rely on reads in order to have good ball hogging.

Despite that, there will be times in which you will know that your opponent isn't going to attempt a steal, despite the fact that they could, or that you know your opponent is going to jump to cover something, so you send a straight angle in order to create a threat that you can recover afterwards.

When such situations arise, you can make use of them. We shouldn't underestimate how taxing it is to ball hog, and if you can find simpler ways to ball hog, even if they aren't as safe, it might be worth going for them.

Just understand that all you need is to mess up a single read and all your hard work to keep the ball will go down the drain. None of us want to be that guy that combos the ball for a minute straight, only to get smash-parried because they thought they could get away with a bunt chain near their opponent.

Baits (dribbles)

Baits are the perfect way to transition between attacks and dribbles. Feigning a simple attack out of a dribble, is a great way to force your opponent to react, allowing you to create some space as they are forced to recover from their actions.

You may also purposefully create a dribble that you know your opponent is going to hit, either to bait out a grabbable parry, or to recover the ball after they hit. Something I also enjoy doing is downbunting the ball, and they immediately parrying it. People will usually react to the sound of a bunt, expecting it to go upwards, and will rush in, hoping to take the ball away from you. This has caught more people off guard than I can ever count, is my go-to serve in the original LL.

Utilizing different rhythms gives you a chance at punishing an opponent that has been conditioned into expecting a particular form of dribbling, often resulting in an easy parry or timing mixup. Also, grabs are an undervalued method of ball hogging. They are simple to catch, but they come out so fast and unexpectedly, that using it to parry an opponent or head shot them works much more often than it should.

In conclusion, always do your best to be unpredictable, and exploit your opponent's expectations when it comes to ball hogging.

Characters



Despite the amount of freedom you get in LLB, all characters have certain mechanics and movement that give them a boost in certain dimensions and tools.

We're going to look at how to categorize yourself as an individual player, but it's also important to understand how to synergize with your character, if you'd like to get the most bang for your buck.

Understand what your character can do and hopefully either adapt your playstyle or pick a character that both heightens your qualities, as well as diminishes your weaknesses.

Just a disclaimer: this part is highly opinionated. You might disagree with much or all of what I write here. However, I ask that you do consider everything that I write here. Just because you make a certain playstyle work, does not mean it's particularly well suited to that character.

Toxic

Toxic isn't as clearly defined as some of the other characters, but she does have some advantages when it comes to ball hogging and offense, as well as a slight defensive boost, particularly through the use of spray.

Some of her angles have just enough deviation from the norm that it allows her to have a slight offensive boost, particularly up, gdown and fspike. You can make a case that air down, up and bspike can be used as good ball hogging angles, as they are either wide or very tight, but her movement and height do take some points away from her ability to control the ball.

Her ability to cling to the wall allows for some good ball hogging, especially if you have a spray down, as the opponent must be weary of the possible reaction check and / or timing mixup. However, her clinging can be somewhat awkward, whereas latch has a much easier time with vertical movement on the wall.

Spray really makes this character, though. It forces your opponent to either tap charge or be very precise, all in a short amount of time. If you have a spray placed somewhere and the ball is flying around, the opponent must be weary of it at all times, and the possibility to send spray into a different direction from your angle is also a big boon. Double sprays and clear, consistent parry setups are great ways to bait and punish your opponent's covers. Finally, you can use spray as a defensive mechanism, eliminating the need to focus on certain spots of the map, or outright covering almost all of your hitbox.

Creativeness is the law with toxic, being able to dish out many complex attacks with relative ease, though you may have to spend some time learning to ball hog in order to execute some of her better offensive options.

Grid

Grid has a great set of tools, for all dimensions.

His angles are wide and varied, allowing for a phenomenal mix of ball hogging and decent attack potential. In particular, his spikes and smash are a great way to either attack or cancel into ball hogging.

His movement can make it hard to get to the ceiling, but his incredible fast fall speed is the perfect way to abuse verticality and continue chains that would be impossible for other characters. Furthermore, his big hitbox is perfect for steals and parry baits, allowing for an uncanny amount of pressure.

Next, his special. It might seem like an offensively driven special, but I would argue that its beauty is in his defensive and ball hogging potential. Due to his hitbox, smashing is usually a great way to cover, especially as you can cancel into his special immediately afterwards. You can create a lot of space with his special, allowing you to control the ball for a very long time.

Finally, his alt special does have some uses. It can be used as a way to immediately transition from a cover into an attack, all in one go, often creating frame traps or bait potential.

Overall, grid is a very solid character, the only downside being that many of his offensive options can be easily defended with the proper knowledge. As such, I recommend putting some time into practicing ball hogging, or creating elaborate offensive baits.

Dice

Dice plays like a rogue with a dagger in most RPGs.

His offensive potential isn't the highest. Almost everything he does can be easily covered with either a bunt or double bunts, with a few exceptions. However, he is perfect when it comes to both ball hogging and defense.

His angles all have clear advantages. Up is great to punish bad positioning and ball hog; down is a good finisher and pretty good for ball hogging; his spikes work similarly to his up angle, allowing you to either ball hog further, or to punish incorrect coverage.

His movement is where he shines. His fast fall is decently fast, allowing you to abuse verticality, especially when coupled with his super jump. And his super jump is one of the best movement tools in the game. It's perfect for very precise interceptive covers, creates a lot of steal potential, helps him reach high balls extraordinarily fast, and allows him to have full control of the air space to ball hog or create complex offensive situations.

Finally, his special. It's not perfect, but it allows for a lot of options, making him a very adaptable character. When it comes to kill potential, it's unlikely that you'll be using it for the sole purpose of attacking, at least not without creating a bait out of it or setting up corner glitch situations. It is, however, yet another tool he has in order to create some distance from the opponent, while keeping BP.

Overall, the perfect character for those who are willing to sacrifice raw offensive prowess for the ability to dance around your opponent and come up with your own plan.

Latch

There is no reason to pretend that Latch doesn't have flaws, because he does. Namely, his offense. It can be very hard to kill with latch, as his angles aren't very threatening.

However, he does have a few good qualities. He is quite good when it comes to ball hogging, especially when you use his special to recover in a pinch. His angles are very wide, which allows him to have long range control, rather than having to rely on very tight ball control.

Furthermore, his wall tech is unparalleled, allowing for a great way to keep the ball at arm's length, as well as punish steal attempts. The wall is also a great place to fall back on if you need to defend. His fastfall is yet another great tool to trip up your opponent and create some distance.

As for his special, it's very basic, but does give you some time to move around and find a better spot, if necessary.

Nonetheless, you will most likely have a hard time killing with him, often having to rely on baits or offensive reads in order to punish your opponents. Though success is definitely possible with this character, his playstyle is not at all straightforward, and you will need a good understanding of nearly everything in the game in order to make up for his low offensive and interceptive potential.

Sonata

Sonata has a lot going for her, making her one of the most versatile characters in the game.

Her angles are both threatening and perfect for ball hogging, allowing you to create hybrid chains very naturally, as well as create elaborate baits to trip up your opponent.

Her special is simple but, just like her angles, has a good mix of kill and ball hogging potential, especially at higher speeds.

Her movement is top notch, having three jumps instead of the usual two. This makes her very good at controlling airspace, allowing you to retreat to a safe space for your ball hogging, as well as follow your opponent omnidirectionally when defending.

If you're already set on spending some time becoming technically proficient, sonata is the perfect choice. She gives you both freedom and power, showing no glaring faults in her kit.

Switch

Switch is a very weird design choice, having incredible tools for nearly everything, yet needing only a fraction of them.

His angles, especially up angle, are amazing for ball hogging, as well as defending, since you can cover with swing without many repercussions.

Despite his ability to ball hog, he doesn't need it all that much. His kill potential is so incredibly high that going for long ball hogging sessions just doesn't make a lot of sense, most of the time.

His special, or rather, specials, are all very strong. He can instantly send the ball to either side, taunt flip when he doesn't have the ball (great both offensively and defensively), cancel out of taunt flip as a way to bait out your opponent, as well as special out of neutral, effectively giving him a 4th angle!

His movement is not that noteworthy, though his float is a great way to use taunt flip for a long amount of time. Wallride is not particularly useful, but you may use it in order to extend your ball control, if you'd like.

Switch is an extraordinary character, giving you a clear and very powerful gameplan. If you value raw offensive strength and impeccable defense, coupled with an innate (though often unnecessary) ball hogging ability, pick him.

Random

Random is a great way to show your opponent that you either don't care about the outcome of the match, or that they are not worthy of you playing a real character.

That's all.

Raptor

Raptor is an offensive and pressure one-man army. Pretty much everything he does is geared toward either killing, or killing some other way.

Yes, you can adapt his tools in order to suit your needs, but he really does shine either when intercepting or creating offensive threats.

His angles are very standard, but all have decent kill potential, other than his spikes, which are mostly only good for ball hogging or baits.

His wall jump is a niche tool, but can be a good way to create some more elaborate setups, as well as safely retreat when in need to defend. Also, he is a lot shorter when compared to the rest of the cast, so he gets a pretty decent boost when it comes to de-pressuring himself.

However, his special absolutely makes this character. It can transition into pretty much any attack type you can think of, and forces you to be aware of his special bar at all times. If you make the mistake of being distracted, chances are, it's going to hit you.

If you like being able to explore, while always being able to fallback on a reliable gameplan, geared toward more offensive play, Raptor is the character for you.

Candyman

Candyman is another character with a very powerful kit. He has tools that help him out in any situation.

For starters, his angles are very powerful offensively, allowing you to take them further beyond with lots of baits at your disposal. Furthermore, they can easily transition into ball hogging, allowing you to reposition, if necessary. He also possesses two of the best spikes in the game, so don't forget to make use of them.

His special is the perfect special in many aspects. It has a very high offensive and ball hogging potential, creating lots of pressure from the moment it's used. It also gives you freedom to use it in either simple or extremely complex chains.

Finally, his movement and mechanics. His floatiness gives him a good boost in ball hogging, as you're able to control the ball in the air very easily. However, this does make candy susceptible to some attacks (i.e. straights). On the other hand, his floatiness does allow him to easily survive lawnmower situations. As for his wallport mechanic, it functions as a de-pressuring, pressuring and ball control tool. You get to wallcamp, approach your opponent to intercept, recatch your long-range angles... and more. If you're not using wall port, you're not doing it right.

Pick candy if, well... you enjoy playing LLB. He gives you freedom to play with most playstyles, his only downside being a minor weakness in both creating and dealing with interceptive pressure.

Jet

Jet has a lot going for her, but is often brushed off due to her lack of raw offensive power. Her angles are subpar (yes, all of them), being extremely easy to catch in most situations.

However, Jet shines when it comes to everything else. Her speed makes her one of the best characters when it comes to interception. Her hover ability is a great way to pressure, ball hog or even de-pressure herself, provided you spend some time practicing with it.

At first glance it might seem like Jet has a bad special, but it does something extremely important: it creates hybrid chains instantly. You get to ball hog, while forcing your opponent to always be wary of engaging. Yes, it can be grabbed, but a good jet player will expect it and usually regain BP out of it.

Especially at low speeds, combining all her tools will make your opponents' lives miserable.

If you're willing to adopt a more complex gameplan, jet might be a good choice. She has an insane amount of ball hogging potential, as well as interceptive ability, in case you lose the ball.

Doombox

Despite having a steep learning curve, Doombox is a very powerful character.

His angles, though not necessarily the best when it comes to offense, are relatively hard to catch in one go. Because of this, your opponent is often forced to safezone one of the angles, allowing you to continue with your ball hogging endeavors. He can also usually recatch them before their opponents, which gives him a lot of baiting potential.

More importantly though, Doombox has a lot of unique mechanics. His size provides him with unparalleled pressure and interceptive power, as well as ball hogging. Approaching Doombox carelessly is a death sentence, so it's often a better idea to play defensively. However, his size also makes him more prone to headshots, so you are forced to be more precise with your positioning.

His flight ability is yet another ball hogging booster, but also serves as a defensive tool, seeing as he is able to safezone anything below him, especially when coupled with his big hitboxes.

His standard special isn't very powerful, but it does force your opponent to come closer, which is DB's preferred setting. However, his alt special, pushbox, is a great offensive tool, and will at least force opponents to jump often, in order to avoid it.

If you don't mind the big learning curve, Doombox is a great min-max character, having some of the best tools in game, as well as some downsides to make up for it.

Nitro

Nitro is a relatively unique character, his playstyle often revolving around long ranged offense.

Nitro's angles are interesting. Similarly to sonata, they provide a great balance of ball hogging and offensive potential, though mainly the latter. Despite that, you are often forced to dance around your opponent in order to defeat your opponent.

His movement can be a little awkward. Despite having very fast vertical mobility, he lacks floatation, thus having to make up for his inability to control the ball, through his special.

His special is, however, very versatile. It gives you the most options out of any other special, allowing you to move around freely, while creating many offensive possibilities, often through frame traps or quick repositioning. However, once an opponent closes in, you might have to drastically shift your focus to a more aggressive playstyle, making use of his speed in order to out compete your opponent in Neutral state.

Nitro gives you either the option to rely on complex ball control in order to confuse your opponent, and persuade them to adopt a more defensive stance, or to apply trickery in order to punish their attempt at coverage or interception.

You should pick Nitro if you find that you have no qualms with changing your gameplan as the situation sees fit, allowing you to outperform your opponent in many different aspects of the game.

Dust & Ashes

The most recent addition to the LLB roster is riddled with challenges that make him a difficult character to pick up.

His angles are by far his most powerful tool, especially when used in conjunction with his parachute ability. They have high kill and baiting potential, but lack the ease of applying ball hogging strategies that some other characters do. Both his up and air down, as well as bspike and fspike, can create complex offensive options.

He also has some boost when it comes to interception, especially due to his aerial prowess, both in floatiness and speed. Parachute is a great way to de-pressure yourself in lawnmower situation, and his fastfall allows you to quickly create some distance from your opponent.

His special, however, is quite poor, as you will most likely lose the race to catch your own ball out of it. You need to be smart with how you use it, often in order to create some distance to your opponent, transitioning into longer ball hogging.

Despite this, dust can be a viable pick if you analyze your opponent's habits, punishing the reads that they are forced to commit when covering, due to the complexity of his angles.

Pick Dust if you are able to think on your feet and have a sharp mind for discovering your opponent's weaknesses, pressuring them at every turn.

Players

To conclude this work, I want to talk about how I believe the knowledge I have detailed here can be applied to both you and your opponents.

Applications & Permutations

For starters, I first try and gauge my opponent's **base playstyle** based on how they play in both BL and BP. In general, people do have a slight bias towards either defense or interception, and offense or ball hogging, on BL and BP respectively.

Say, for example, that a player is about 30% defensive and 70% interceptive. This doesn't necessarily mean that they will be better at interception than defense, but it does mean that our games will usually be closer-quarters and that I should try and adapt my own playstyle in order to fight theirs.

Against highly interceptive players, I can either try and out-perform their interceptive ability with my own ball hogging ability, making use of tools that directly counter theirs, or try and abuse their often sup-par positioning to boost my offensive options.

For example, if they are heavy on pressure and analysis with their interception, applying a fair amount of ball hogging de-pressure, as well as complex ball control, should both diminish their pressure and analysis, forcing them to rely on other tools.

In the other hand, I might actually let them try and pressure me in order to punish their eagerness to get the ball. As we talked about beforehand, interception is it's own game, and the interceptor does often end up in below average defensive positions when trying to take the ball from you, so parry or timing mixups, end up being a common method of shutting down their steal attempts.

On the opposite side of the spectrum, we can see a player who is about 40% ball hoggish, and 60% offensive. This a minor difference, but it does show where their priorities lie.

I would approach this situation by applying a high amount of defensive de-pressure, facilitating my ability to cover the ball, not necessarily having a big focus on interception.

However, you can also argue that being very interceptive is an equally valid approach since, due to their lack of focus on ball hogging, you might have an easier time just out-right shutting down their offense by taking the ball away from them.

The point I am trying to make here is that there are countless ways to go about these situations, all equally valid. I have found a lot of success in simply countering my opponents.

However, top level play will hinge on each players ability to adapt to each other. Everyone has a base playstyle, but throughout the course of the match or matches, each player will end up adapting and counter-adapting to each other.

The important point is to never be stuck doing a single thing. Many players end up developing a certain dimension or tool, say, they practice offense and ball control to a very high level.

However, if you are unable to let go of said playstyle, you will end up being countered by someone eventually. It's like going to the gym and only practicing your right arm. Yes, you might win at arm wrestling if you fight a right-handed opponent, but what will you do when he switches to his bigger left arm?

The cliché of “you learn the most with your losses” is especially true here. If you lose a certain matchup, it's likely that you have a particular imbalance that you should pinpoint and work at. It might also have been that you were just unable to find the right winning strategy in time, and that is why spending some time analyzing your games and the games of others is very important. This will give you a better intuition, which will in turn allow you to much more quickly adapt in game.

Now, I'm not telling you to stop mid match to think about the perfect strategy. That wouldn't be feasible. But having the right feeling as to where you should try and gear your playstyle when facing a tough opponent will change your ability in game tremendously.

I am a firm believer in balance. The closer you can get your base playstyle to 50% on each dimension, the better prepared you will be to adapt on the spot. This also applies to tools. If you're constantly relying on reads or analysis to get your way, it is a big indicator that you might want to spend some time improving your ball control or pressure.

Analyzing for Growth

Beyond just utilizing this method during matches, it might be most useful to apply it outside of serious sets.

Understanding what it is you are missing is a complicated affair, so having clear guidelines might help you make sense of what it is you are missing, rather than

going into training mode for the 20th time that week, trying to find a better mixup, or just playing game after game, not really doing anything differently.

Don't just play mindlessly. Always be active in your learning process. It's no use playing 20.000 matches if you're not trying to improve in each one. You can even double or even triple your growth each match by recording them and analyzing them afterwards with a fresh mind, free of in-game stress. In fact, this might be the best way to apply this whole methodology.

Find your flaws in others. If this was a single-player game, it would be much easier to identify things to improve on. However, you constantly have to measure your abilities against other, and understanding why you succeed or fail, should be your number one priority.

Also, get creative. If you come to the realization that you have a hard time keeping the ball against a pressuring interceptor, find drills that help you keep the ball for as long as possible.

Repetition is vital, especially when it comes to mastering a skill, but a valid environment, as well as consistent feedback, is equally important.

If you want to get better at a particular skill, you need to devise ways to practice said skill over many repetitions, in an environment that allows you to understand when you are doing better.

This is also why high ping games tend to frustrate players. It does allow for many repetitions, but it's not a valid environment, since you'll often die to completely unrelated issues to the one at hand. If you're practicing your tap charging skills, doing so with a friend is much better than doing it during a match, as you will be able to do more repetitions, with clearer feedback that doesn't rely on your ability to get to the correct position in time, as well as react to everything that your opponent can throw at you.

Also, don't be afraid to ask for opinions. How are you supposed to understand that you are missing something if you aren't aware that you are missing something? It's a funny conundrum, but getting over your pride and asking those are you for help can be the perspective shift you need in order to find the missing piece of the puzzle.

I highly recommend sending your matches to someone whose playstyle you respect. Having a fresh set of eyes on your playstyle is the perfect way to fill in the gaps in your knowledge.

Mentality

Mentality is also a very important aspect when it comes to improving. I have gone through many toxic mental states throughout my time in LLB and LL1, and each time I have learned to steer clear of them.

The number one aspect to understand is that someone whose only goal is to be very good, is probably not going to be very good (or at least not for long). If you want to be consistent with your improvement, you need passion, and the most consistent form of passion, the one that won't burn you out after a year of playing, is fun.

If you're not having fun, you will eventually pay dearly for it. If you decide that being good is more important than enjoying your time, or if you only enjoy your time when you are winning, then you're in an unsustainable mental environment. You will eventually either burn out of the game, or become bitter.

I have seen dozens of players who, by the end of their competitive careers, seem to play more due to an obligation of playing, rather than any actual enjoyment. They don't even feel like they enjoy winning anymore. However, their week is ruined if they lose a set.

No one is perfect, and you're sure to fall on bad times eventually, but the most important takeaway is to not let results dictate your path. If you're afraid of losing, you won't prioritize improving.

Losing should be an enjoyable process. It shows that you still have so much to learn! I do have a bad tendency to get annoyed when I lose to things or players that I feel I should "roll over". However, once I start to do this, I will become bitter and purposefully try and do the things that got me killed, trying to prove that it was just a fluke, slowly losing more and more games in the process.

As such, I recommend doing something that might be a bit silly. Whenever you lose, rather than groaning in frustration, try and smile and appreciate your opponent's ability to punish you – "Bravo!"

Finally, understand when to stop overthinking. We tend to constantly have a million thoughts going over our head when playing. This is good, it allows you to improve in most situations, but if your goal is to win (such as when playing an important set in a tournament), having a clear mind and letting your hard work do the heavy lifting, thus only having to focus on higher order details, will allow you to truly play your best.

If you find that you are always nervous going into a game, it helps me to just accept whatever outcome might arise from the match, before it even happens. I used to almost always lose my first game each tournament, even as when I was one of the top seed in a tournament. However, I wouldn't have that problem when fighting stronger

opponents, seeing as I was already very aware of the possibility of losing. This is because the nerves of potentially failing and humiliating myself when fighting someone “worse” than me, were holding me back. But since I started thinking “Ok, I might lose against this person. That’s okay, it’s not the end of the world.”, it hasn’t happened again.

To end this section, as well as this guide, I have a little mantra I’d like to share with you. Maybe you’ll enjoy it:

“Work hard, stay humble, but be proud of your achievements.”

Closing Thoughts

If you've read this far, I'm very thankful. This whole project was a lot of fun to write, and I hope that maybe you'll get something out of it.

I do understand that a lot of it might be somewhat difficult to understand without some sort of visual aid. However, that was never my goal. I intended this more as a compendium of theory, rather than an exercise and example workbook.

I believe that sets of videos for each of the chapters in this book might be the perfect medium, but I have neither the time, ability, nor the patience, to do so. I hope you understand.

I created this more for myself than anyone else, so if even a single person finds it useful, then I'm already pleasantly surprised.

Regardless, if you found this "guide" interesting, feel free to give me some feedback. I'd love to hear your thoughts.

Also, don't be afraid to reach out to me if you have any questions. I'd be delighted to clarify any questions you might have.

Thank you for reading!

- CT